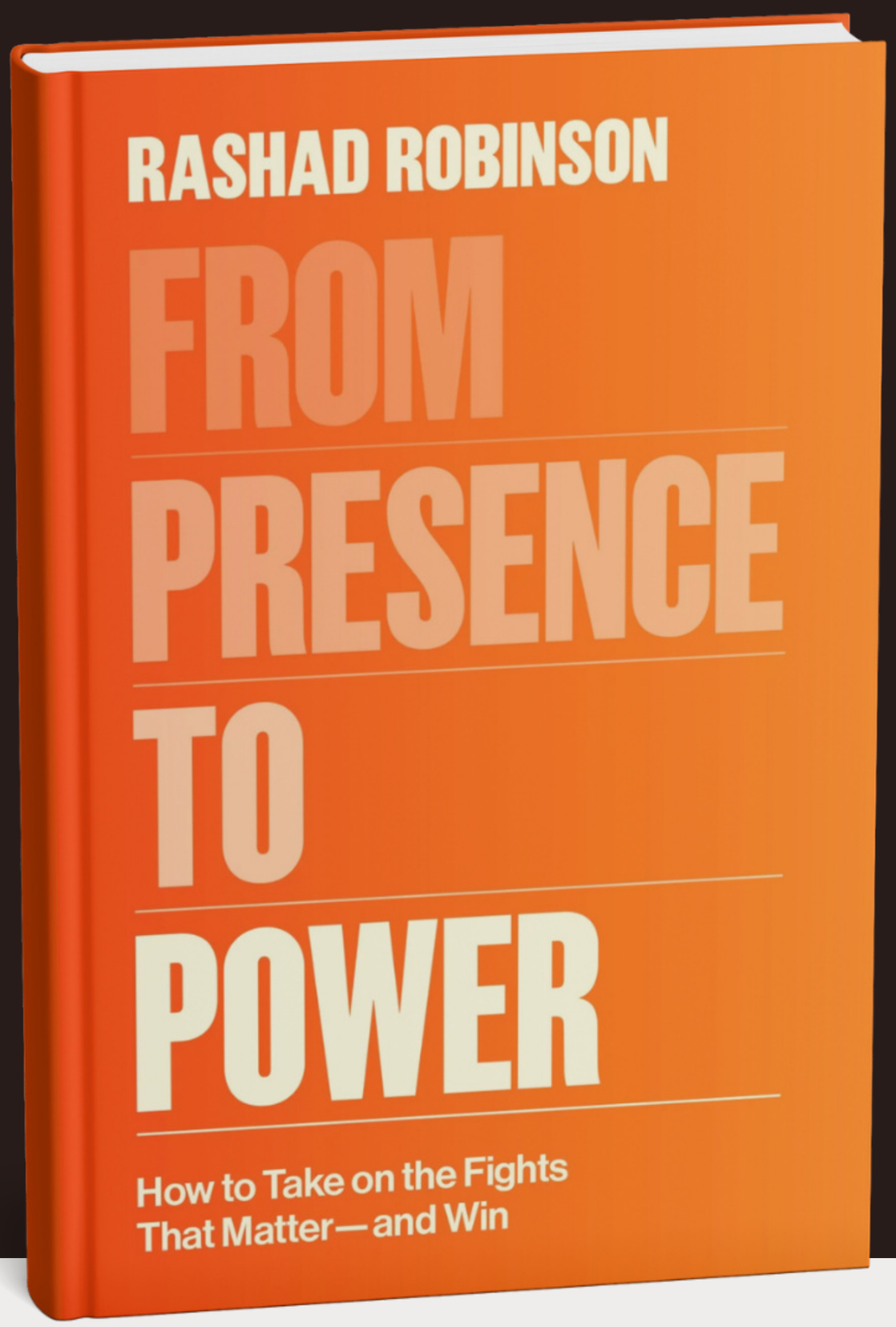
Book Club Discussion Guide

FROM PRESENCE TO POWER



“Social change is the practice of making the impossible possible, and possibility is about one thing more than any other: power.”



RASHAD ROBINSON

Dear friends,

Thank you for choosing *From Presence to Power* for your book club. This is one of my favorite ways for people to engage with the book. I wrote this book intending that people like you would mark it up, learn from it, challenge it, and put it to work. There's no better place for that than a book club.

Long before the book was finished, I kept watching people care, show up, vote, march, donate and post, and still struggle to understand why the things they cared about weren't changing. We've given people plenty of ways to express what they believe, but not nearly enough tools for understanding how power actually works and how to build it. Power is collective, and a book club gives you the chance to move from individual reflection to collective analysis, and maybe to collective action. It happens when people compare notes about their own workplaces, congregations, schools and neighborhoods. That's when they start to notice where attention has been mistaken for leverage, or a seat at the table for a say in the outcome. That's the shift at the heart of this book, moving from being seen to actually changing the rules.

I hope you'll take these ideas further. Figure out where you agree with me, where you don't, and why. Build on these ideas and tweak them. Do the Find Your Power exercises together and compare what you come up with. Bring in the fights you're part of right now, and the ones you've been putting off, and test the book against them.

And I want to push you a bit. Don't stop at a good conversation about the book. As a group, pick something you want to change. Figure out who has the power to change it, and what power the people in your room already have that could be organized. I want book clubs like yours to be places where people start practicing these ideas.

I also hope the conversation turns into something that lasts beyond the last chapter. Every win I write about was built on relationships, on people who kept showing up for each other before the moment arrived and long after it passed. That kind of community starts in rooms like yours. What we have is each other, and that's always where power starts.

And again, thank you.

RASHAD

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

* HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

The questions follow the arc of the book, from understanding power to putting it to work. You don't need to cover them all. Choose one or two per theme, or spend a whole session on a single theme. The Find Your Power exercises at the end of most chapters pair well with these questions, and a selection is available online at book.rashadrobinson.com/fyp.

01 UNDERSTAND POWER

- How did reading the book change the way you define power?
- How is your definition different from the way we usually talk about power?

02 DIAGNOSE THE PROBLEM

The book separates harm we call "unfortunate" from harm we call "unjust." The first gets charity and the second demands accountability. Robinson links Katrina in 2005 to the Los Angeles fires in 2025 through the phrase "natural disaster."

- Where else do you see injustice described as bad luck or as inevitable?
- Who benefits when it's described that way, and what changes when it's named correctly?

According to Robinson, many advocates mistake dialogue for negotiation.

- Have you ever seen an organization, movement, workplace, or institution celebrate having “a seat at the table” when it actually did not have the power to influence outcomes?
- What signs tell you the difference?

03 IDENTIFY WHO BENEFITS

The book argues that injustice lasts because someone profits from it, so moral arguments alone rarely move the people who benefit.

- Pick an injustice you care about.
- Who profits from it, and what would it take to make it unprofitable?

04 LOCATE LEVERAGE

Robinson says the unwritten rules of culture often decide whether the written rules mean anything.

- What unwritten rules shape your workplace, school, congregation or community?
- How would anyone go about changing a rule that was never written down?

The book describes most people as spectators of politics rather than players, and says there's a position on the field for everyone.

- Which roles do you already hold, like parent, teacher, worker, neighbor or churchgoer, could become sources of power?
- What's kept you from using them that way?

05 BUILD BELIEF

The book calls belief the first tool any movement needs, and treats it as something communities build together, not just a matter of personal optimism.

- What do leaders, organizations and communities have to do to build belief among people who have been disappointed again and again?
- Have you ever been part of something that changed not just what people believed, but who they believed themselves to be and what they believed they could do together?

BEFORE YOU CLOSE
START PRACTICING POWER

As a group, choose one thing you'd like to change in your workplace, school, neighborhood, congregation, city or the country.

- Who has the power to give you what you want?
- What do they currently have an incentive to do?
- What power do the people in this room have, individually and collectively, that could change that incentive?

As a closing reflection, ask each other: What is one thing you will do differently after reading this book, not just something you now believe differently?

GO DEEPER

* “Magical thinking,” as Robinson defines it, is believing something is true because we want it to be, including the belief that progress is inevitable.
  - Where are you, or institutions you’re part of, engaging in magical thinking right now?
  - Since winning changes the battlefield rather than ending the fight, how do you build for progress while preparing for the backlash it can bring?

* Robinson writes, “The challenge for us now and in the years ahead is to become more powerful than those forces, not just more popular.”
  - Why can visibility feel like victory even when the underlying incentives haven’t changed? Where have you seen that happen?

* Many people underestimated Donald Trump, Robinson argues, because they failed to understand the political power of popular culture.
  - What other examples, from the book or your own experience, show popular culture creating or turning into political power?

* The book argues that social change in media requires both “raising the ceiling” (creating new possibilities and stories) and “raising the floor” (making harmful narratives less acceptable and less profitable). It also argues that a narrative only matters when it changes behavior, incentives and decisions, not just opinions.
  - Think of a story that has shifted in your lifetime. Did it change what people actually do?

* When powerful institutions face pressure, they often offer fixes that leave underlying incentives unchanged.
  - Why are “fake solutions” so persuasive?
  - What examples from the book, or from current events, fit Robinson’s definition?

* Sometimes we have to redefine what a role is for before we can change how the person in that role behaves. The book shows how that worked with prosecutors.
  - Where else in society might that be true?

* The book argues that every political fight is now also a corporate fight, and every corporate fight is political.
  - Where does your leverage sit in those fights? Think about the roles you occupy: worker, voter, donor, creator, customer, investor, board member, congregation member, alum.

RESOURCES & MORE

* HOW WE WIN NEWSLETTER

Biweekly newsletter from Rashad Robinson on power, culture and strategy.

Subscribe: www.rashadrobinson.com/newsletter

* FIND YOUR POWER EXERCISES

From Presence to Power offers hands-on, practical exercises that readers can use on their own, or with groups, to see opportunities for becoming more effective change-makers. You'll find them at the end of most chapters, and a selection is available online at book.rashadrobinson.com/fyp.

* SHARE YOUR EXPERIENCE

Post about your experience reading the book: a photo of your group or book club, or a picture of your marked-up copy. Tag Rashad on Instagram at @iamrashadrobinson.

* MEET RASHAD

For upcoming book events, or to invite Rashad to your community, visit frompresencetopower.org.